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The Rise and Fall of Mt. Cleverest[Jeff Cunningham](#)

10/17/2003

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Type II - CHK
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[Editor's note: This article is only a portion of a much larger effort put forth by Jeff's PT Boston team. Be sure to check out both Tomi Walamies' and Brett Shears' reports [\[HERE\]](#). - Ray]

Jeff here. All alone. As usual.

Okay, a few things before we continue, just some notes I feel are necessary after reading his portion of the report.

**Articles**

News Archive
 Extended - CHK
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1. What's with the name? Prince Mise... huh? Tomi... just between you and me, the whole "mise" fad is a little passe. Perhaps something more ambitious, "Climbing Mount Cleverest: Teens Scream When They See The Cream in This Team -- Part II: Before Boston, Boston, and Beyond!"? "Charles Barkley's: Shut Up and Jam"? "Meet the stupids" maybe?

2. I didn't want to be "Thanksgiving" so that I "could say thanks barn to our opponents," but rather as nod to the indigenous peoples of the Americas. The team name I really wanted to go with was "Where's Waldo." Tomi and I would dress normally, but then Brett would be wearing a red and white striped sweater, and a matching beret.

He would be Waldo. Haha.

3. Now hold on just one darn second...people (French?) were trying to convince you to leave my team? Question-- is this some sort of sick joke? Are there candid cameras somewhere?

True or false: I routinely collect paychecks from the World's best at every Pro Tour stop with memos reading "3-0'd another moneydraft"?

True or false: I make Bob Maher Jr look like Bob Maher Sr?

TRUE OR FALSE: My play style is pure Justin Polin, with the technical ability of Ben Seck, and the jedi mind tricks of Jeff Fung?

....

That one's false.

Anyway, I play well, I play hard. And now I get treated like... like a goddam barnacle?

I took you under my wing, my little wounded bird Tomi, and I nursed you back to health from a nothing, with milk from my body.

When I saw his friends mocking me so openly, and so hurtfully, I was mortified. Europeans can be so cruel.

Round 4 -- Gallop's Comics and Games

3-0, and sitting pretty after defeating the evil alliance of Andrew Wolf (renowned among Brett and I for his almost encyclopedic array of facial expressions, and canny decision-making instincts) Ben Seck ("your team is the nut low" - Ben Seck,) and Daniel Zink.

We sit down to play our matches... My W/R vs U/R, Brett's R/G vs R/G, and Tomi's U/B vs U/W.

About a minute in, a judge comes over to Brett bearing his decklist. Not what you want to see.

"You didn't register any land."

Brett's totally relaxed though, and I assume there's some sort of confusion.

"No, they're there. Right there." Brett kind of points around to the back of the sheet (which the judge is holding up.)

The judge looks to where Brett is pointing, and there are still, clearly, no lands registered.

"Uh... no they're not."

Finally, confronted with logic, the jig is up, "Yeah, I guess they're not."

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I shoot Brett a look that says "you're sleeping on the couch tonight," and he knows he's in the doghouse.

(By the way, here's a suggestion for a new addition to the floor rules. Instead of a player receiving a game loss when they misregister they're deck with no land, they should just have to play it out with no land at all. Like when your dad makes you smoke all the cigarettes in the pack so you'll never do it again.)

My match is going very well so far, though. Despite [Lightning Rift](#) on his side, he's three or four cards down just from my white morph tricks, and small things like that. He has a card in hand, and a [Mistform Wall](#) in play versus my [Skittish Valesk](#), and my five cards in hand. I'm at twenty and he's at five.

This is one of those games where I'm thinking in my head "I wonder what series of events would have to occur in order for me to lose this game?" I'm like... [Timetwister](#) into Lotus Lotus Wrath Timewalk [Masticore](#)... nope, that doesn't do it. The next three or four turns consist of me missing the flip on Valesk (if it stays up, I can make him chump, and drop another backbreaking guy,) and then umorphing it, and making him block. Finally, he draws his eight land and drops... Akroma MF T!

Obviously, it's a beating, but still not enough to win on its own... I have a full hand, and I'm a twenty. I start to unload, but at this point it's almost as if he had God mode on. I couldn't touch him. His deck was a never-ending supply of [Choking Tethers](#) and [Renewed Faiths](#). Well, that was absolute highway robbery. On to game 2!

I will say this -- to Brett's credit, he didn't wander off after his penalty. He knew he had to sit it out, and watch each agonizing moment. Yes, he screwed up, but he took his punishment like a man.

Game 2, I get a slow draw, but have [Insurrection](#) in my hand. You know, that old chestnut. Focus on stalling the board, get to eight land, makes sure the coast is clear, and then tap your mana, and slide the card to your opponent face down across the table. He looks under it, nods, and cleans up his cards. There's no reason to make a huge scene, let the man go with a little dignity.

Tom's won his match at this point, so it's all on me.

Game 3:

Everything that could go wrong, went wrong. Whenever he couldn't have it, he had it. Whenever I needed to not draw it, I drew it, and whenever I needed to draw it, he drew it. I was Rifted, [Complicated](#), Combobulated, [Willbender](#). At one point I needed to hit for 4 with [Erratic Explosion](#) just to stay alive. I did. Unfortunately inbetween he [Willbender](#)d it to my only creature.

They carried me away on a stretcher.

Mnt C: 3-1

I lose it a bit during the match, throwing a chair at my own head, but they were good guys. After the round I go outside, and calm myself down. Sometimes, Magic can be brutal. That's why they call it "Bloodsport."

Inwardly, I forgive Brett, and put the incident behind me. Brett Shears is awesome and he would give game losses to game losses if that was possible, and I know it was also my fault for not checking his decklist.

I even go so far as to slip a small note that says "I forgive you" into our next set of decks. Instead of easing everything, though, it turns into a misunderstanding and freaks them out, because they think that the decks have been tampered with, or something, I guess. It was straight out of Meet the Parents, with me as Ben Stiller and Tom as DeNiro.

Kenny Hsiung won the Week in Review Contest on Community Issues, in which I promised a reader a chance to get to shout something out in one of my reports. Though that column is now defunct, I intend to honour my promise. Let's see what Kenny has to say!

Deckbuilding: a Dangerous Game by Kenny Hsiung

"during deck construction i suddenly was reminded of a time in my childhood when i was ridiculed because of my odd skin complexion. I told myself that one day I would fight in the Kumite and make my father proud. And then I realized - today was that day. We were going to win the Kumite boys. Oh yes we were.

i feel that the college basket ball team the North Carolina Tarheels should be changed to the north carolina tar haleels - not only would it be more appropriate for haleel, but it would give us all the opportunity to see jeff fung wear a shirt that said tar haleel on it"

To quote "Billy Madison":

Mr. Hsiung, what you have just said is one of the most insanely idiotic things I have ever heard. At no point in your rambling, incoherent response were you even close to anything that could resemble a rational thought. Everyone in this room is now dumber for having listened to it. I award you no points, and may God have mercy on your soul.

Our next set of decks aren't great, but have a few treats. Silvos, double [Lavamancer's Skill](#), [Goblin Sharpshooter](#). Brett gets a mediocre B/G deck that's a husk for Silvos, Tom's with his standard U/R powerhouse, and I have a strong W/R deck.

Round 5: vGG (Tommi Hovi, Nicolai Herzog, & Mattias Jorstedt)

I guess these guys were good, once upon a time.

I'm paired up against Tommi Hovi, aka Father Goose.

Game 1: I get a turn 2 [Sunstrike Legionnaire](#), followed up by a pair of [Wingbeat Warriors](#), and that's simply too much for his below average power level R/G deck to deal with.

Game 2: A similar draw, with the Legionnaire, a flyer, and a [Dragon Scales](#). [Noble Templar](#) comes down, and then [Torrent of Fire](#) finishes it on the following turn.

Sometimes W/R annihilates R/G, and other times the green guys just feel unstoppable. I suppose it's a matter of killing them with flyers before they can fully take advantage.

Brett loses to Jorstedt's monster of a deck (I actually had to call the judge to make sure Mattias didn't bring it from Sweden in a brown paper bag,) but Tomi manages to solidly defeat Herzog using a little something I like to call the 720 [Pemmin's Aura](#)-into-[Lavamancer's Skill](#).

Mnt. C: 4-1

After this round, Brett and I see the team that beat us last round playing against Kai's team, and I realize what has occurred. Brett, in making his grievous error, has altered the time-space continuum, our grand destiny! We were supposed to play that match! We were supposed to defeat the Phoenix Foundation before they could win again! And now... they're taking off in the bracket above ours, out of reach. Could we catch them, stop them, before it was too late? Could we save Doc, and Clara? Did I just kiss my own mom?? I was fading from the photographs, and Biff was gambling his way to millions. Alternate futures flickered before my eyes... Marty Jr... jailed?

Not like this.

... not like this...

Round 6: Trogdor, the Burninator (?)

A very important match. Do you end the day feeling good at 5-1, or crowding into day 2 like a dink at 4-2, hoping to make four hundred bucks?

We are paired against some Seattle players I know from my PTQ days: Josh Lytle, Brian Petersen, and Daniel Hansen, who I'm paired against.

Game 1 and Game 2 both involve his accelerated large green guys and Butcher [Orgg](#) (fetched with [Fierce Empath](#).) outclassing my white non-flyers. By his own admission, he makes a few sub-optimal plays, but nothing drastic, and I get crushed.

Tomi, on the other hand, is matched up vs U/W, what we hoped for. Everything is going as planned, skill of the lava-man dominates the first game, but is removed in the second. [Pemmin's Aura](#), however, goes unanswered, and ends it.

It's all down to Brett, and it's a nailbiter game 3 I can't bear to watch. The clunky B/G deck, all hopes resting on a Silvos and a [Sootfeather Flock](#), versus the streamlined R/B deck with four or five creatures in play, one of which is a Murkdiver, and a [Searing Flesh](#) in hand! I just have to walk away, think good thoughts, get some water, and hope there'll be good news when I get back.

Dare I think of the sweetest fruit the Team Pro Tour has to offer? Losing your match and yet winning the round? The forbidden delicacy. And yet, when I return, there is rejoicing. Brett pulled it out before his opponent had a chance to cast the Flesh.

I hug him. He hugs me. The moment passes. Awkward.

Mnt. C: 5-1

Something that I find a little surprising in Team Limited at the Pro Tour is that metagaming your decks often works. Take this excerpt from Matt Rubin's report: "Prior to the PT, we had agreed to basically mirror our draft strategy in the Rochester in the sealed deck portion, since we decided who was the best with each particular deck." Believe it or not, most teams work this way. Since most people follow conventional draft strategy, you can make reasonable predictions about where most people will put their colours, and plan accordingly. Every sealed, we gave Tomi a deck that was good against white, and he played against it five out of six rounds! Our only loss on Day One was due to Brett's misregistration, and I attribute a good deal of that success to strong pairings for each of us all day long.

We do a practice draft vs. eventual finalists the Original Slackers, and then Tomi and I go get some food while Brett eats some nuts he found and a few berries from the bushes outside. Brett is a survivalist to an extreme degree... an also a purveyor of Native American hunting methods (again, the name Thanksgiving.) He only takes what he needs to survive from the land, nothing more. He spends little, since he knows he truly needs so little to get by. In Draft, he uses the cards like the Indian use the Buffalo. Nothing is wasted. Unplayable cards are ripped to become counters, off-color cards get written on and become proxied lands.

Often, he will go foraging. Packing up money draft commons lying on the ground that others had tossed away. He orders them, and sells them on ebay for a minimal sum. Oh, it's not much, and the work is hard, but he gets by. He did not taxi, or even shuttle in from the airport, despite landing at 12AM the night before the tournament. He took the bus, for seventy five cents.

If you're familiar with my beliefs, you'll know that his are antithetical. Focus on the tournament, I say, everything else should just be convenient. However, I still respect Brett's views; they are not borne of cheapness, but out of a respect for the Mother Nature.

For instance, even though he could sell Draft Sets three for \$20, he sold three for \$18. Straight up, keep your two dollars. Brett could eat on that two dollars. But eating is less important to him than being fair with another human being.

Myself, I charge \$25. Then, I've grown accustomed to my westernized life. I have to pay mortgages, car payments, child support. Brett shirks these frivolous commitments in favor of the philosophy of Martin Luther: "for it is mean, iniquitous, and servile for a Christian man, with his freedom, to be subjected to any regulations except the heavenly and divine." Also, "reason is the Devil's whore." Well isn't that something.

I suspect that the reasons Brett so often starts well, and then finishes poorly at these events are subconscious. He doesn't want the money, because he doesn't want it to corrupt him. Hopefully, one day he will get past this, and we can see someone who actually deserves the money get some.

I heard that Kai Budde paid someone \$400 to eat poo. Is that responsible? Is that respectful? Is that even sanitary?

The answer to all of these questions, of course, is no, and one day Kai will probably give Brett smallpox. Then take his wallet.

Our gameplan is Red/White in the A Seat, Black/Blue in the B seat (since, I think, in this format, if built properly Black/Blue can beat any deck... kind of like the way Green/Blue was in O/T/J...) and Green/X (usually Red,) in the C seat.

In hindsight, I would've put Green/Black in the C seat as the default. The C Seat match is almost always green on green, and there, [Dragon Shadow](#) can be the most important card. It can beat Timberwatch, and that's the main problem. Also, this would give more Red to the R/W deck, which needs the help, and less cards to the B/U deck, which often has good stuff to spare.

I love coming back to the hotel after Day 1, when you've made it to Day 2, because you're always so bagged that you get an incredible sleep.

Magic Online Etiquette: Far be it from me to criticize anyone's social graces -- I once spat in a man's face for being called a coward-- but I feel the need to comment on a particular MODO behavioral issue. It is rude for the winner of a match to say "gg" unless the losing player says so first. It comes off as arrogant, and denies the disadvantaged player the chance to salvage dignity by being a gentleman. It is doubly rude to declare "gg" when the game isn't over, as one player did to me after [Diverting](#) my [Opportunity](#) to himself! Sure, that's good beats... but it isn't good manners.

Round 7: Zabutan Nemonaut (Mike Turian, Eugene Harvey, Gary Wise)

Me old messmates. The draft was interesting, Tomi was U/B vs W/B, which I think pretty strongly favors U/B, I was R/G vs U/G, which I think (perhaps contrary to popular belief,) favours R/G, and Brett was W/R vs B/R (already favours B/R, and Eugene's deck was insane.) I think we drafted very well this round, and a few of the so-called mistakes Turian questions in the interview after the draft (the [Enrage](#) pick, for instance,) were the best, most difficult, decisions in the entire draft. Yes, we know [Enrage](#) is not generally good, but in a matchup where I'm going to be the aggressor, and it looks as though I'll be able to get a creature through when I need it to, when I have, and am playing, double [Dragon Fangs](#) (another key to Green on Green matchups,) and have a total of 4 spells, [Enrage](#) can be very very good.

The deckbuild was also fairly interesting, as I had a ton of options, but way too many cards. See how you would have played it.

2 [Elvish Warrior](#)
1 [Snarling Undorak](#)
1 [Taunting Elf](#)
1 [Airborne Aid](#)
1 [Mage's Guile](#)
1 [Break Open](#)
1 [Krosan Groundshaker](#)
1 [Krosan Tusker](#)
1 [Warped Researcher](#)
1 [Dripping Dead](#)
1 [Goblin Lookout](#)
1 [Macetail Hystrodon](#)
1 [Towering Baloth](#)
1 [Treespring Lorian](#)
1 [Wirewood Herald](#)
1 [Goblin Dynamo](#)
1 [Skirk Marauder](#)
1 [Skirk Outrider](#)
1 [Accelerated Mutation](#)
1 [Hunting Pack](#)
1 [Krosan Drover](#)
1 [Kurgadon](#)
1 [Berserk Murlodont](#)
1 [Krosan Vorine](#)
2 [Stonewood Invoker](#)
1 [Timberwatch Elf](#)
1 [Wirewood Hivemaster](#)
1 [Krosan Warchief](#)
1 [Titanic Bulvox](#)
1 [Enrage](#)
1 [Claws of Wirewood](#)
2 [Dragon Fangs](#)
1 [Daru Lancer](#)
1 [Defensive Maneuvers](#)
1 [Shaleskin Plover](#)
1 [Defiant Elf](#)
1 [Daru Spiritualist](#)
1 [Mercurial Kite](#)
1 [Bladewing's Thrall](#)
1 [Fatal Mutation](#)

You can see my final build [\[here\]](#) if you're interested.

I won't spoil the surprise, but I definitely had my beer goggles on, cuz for some reason [Titanic Bulvox](#) was looking mighty good that deckbuild.

I just kept reading the card going, "...this guy is ... awesome. Brett... it's a 7/4."

Game 1: I curve out, and get him to 14 before his Timberwatch locks up the ground. Even though he has that, I have a [Stonewood Invoker](#) in play, [Wirewood Herald](#), and two Morphs ([Treespring Lorian](#), and [Titanic Bulvox](#)), and [Enrage](#) in hand. He plays a [Shoreline Ranger](#) on his turn 6, and I flip up Lorian. My turn, I attack with everything, the morph gets blocked, and I flip the 'Vox... the net result is a trade with the Ranger, and pushing Turian down to 8. He plays another creature on the following turn, and I attack knowing that unless he blocks both of my creatures (which would result in me being able to search up a Timberwatch,) he's dead. He doesn't, so I [Enrage](#) him down to 1, and [Claws of Wirewood](#) him next turn.

Bulvox. The man wins games, people. Get that in your little indented heads.

Game 2: On the draw, here's the hand: [Taunting Elf](#), [Stonewood Invoker](#), [Stonewood Invoker](#), [Timberwatch Elf](#), [Dragon Fangs](#), [Forest](#). You don't mulligan one landers like this.

He plays turn one [Taunting Elf](#)... I draw... some Morph. Play me Elf.

He plays land, says go (a mistake... why not attack? If I draw a forest I can Fangs up my [Taunting Elf](#) to kill his!)

Come on deck, let me put him away. Peel it.

Non-land... oh boy. I nudge.

He draws, plays a Morph, and I draw... Oh, can you feel it? A [Forest](#), God bless its little heart.

And the turn after that I draw another [Forest](#), then another, and [Willbender](#) on a Timberwatch for about 7 doesn't even slow me down, and then another [Forest](#), and finally an [Enrage](#) to end it.

I look over at Brett's match. It looks bad. Eugene plays a Visara. Brett calls him a sleezebag. Brett concedes. You know, pretty much the usual.

Tomi's up a game, however. The second one is looking very bad, but he fights for control, and eventually, thanks to a few small but decisive mistakes from Gary, he regains the advantage, and is going to win barring anything drastic.

I can tell you the exact moment when Mount Cleverest peaked: Wise taps eight mana for [Akroma, Angel of Wrath](#), and Tomi taps three and [Ixidor's Wills](#) it. Everything we had worked for, encapsulated into a single play.

Mnt. C: 6-1

If only you could have been there. It was glorious! God, sometimes I love this game!

6-1 in a team Pro Tour is like 8-1 in a normal Pro Tour. The Top 4 was just over the horizon. Finally out of the middle of the pack.

But then, you can't outrun the continuum forever. If you miss your grand destiny, no matter on how slight an error, there can be no success. Short term gains, perhaps... but eventually, it all catches up. Like those guys in the white van that shot at Marty, but then Doc had the vest on. But we had no vest, you see? You fools.

What you're about to witness is one team's long fall down. It began in slow motion, and before we realized what was happening, we had lost our balance and plunged into the abyss. Kai (Biff.) (M.Bison.) my arch-enemy, watched from above and let out a deep-throated laugh.

Hey... you guys ever get the feeling that Kai Budde is out there specifically just to get you? Is it only me? It's like the man's got my nuts in a goddam vise.

Thanks for reading, guys. I'm sorry about the whole Week in Review thing. It's a long story, and now is neither the time nor the place, but let's just say I was sexually harassed by two attractive female employees of Wizards of the Coast and I didn't feel comfortable working there anymore. It got weird.

A huge thank you to "#1 fan" Beonka Zinger who drew this picture of me. Thank you, it warmed my heart in these cold cold times.



Cya!

- [Jeff Cunningham](#)

[**Editor's note:** If you liked this article by Jeff, be sure to check out his other great articles. - Ray]

Title	Writer	Date	Article Type
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Pro Tour Venice: This Is Awkward (55th)	Jeff Cunningham	4/8/2003	Strategy: OnBC
UG Madness: Matchup Analysis vs. Astral Slide	Jeff Cunningham	3/7/2003	Strategy: Type II
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Card Flipper

What the hell no one cares about team limited or what. I think it is one of the funnest formats in magic.

Anyway awesome article Jeff.

Oh ya my team at Boston had to play Herzog's team first round, and let's say they had a much better card pool than us, and much better than the one you guys faced. highlights Hovi's c deck had riptide shapeshifter, kilnmouth and rorix, which he got to use on our c player like this play shapeshifter, next turn, attack w it activate, say dragon, flip through deck to kilnmouth, put it into play and show Rorix in hand hahahaha. I got to play Niko, and his w b control was too much once he got it set up, crowd fav, smokespew, i actually got rid of his crowd fav one game and he rips doomed necromancer off the top lol. Oh ya Matthias had slice and dice and a buncha broken stuff. Is it just me or do the pros seem to get effin hooked up on their card pool whereas the best card we had all day was arcanis. P.S. i ran the Arcanis in my u w, played first, missed my 6th land drop and my opponent drops arcanis on his turn 6. Needless to say we didnt make day 2 with luck like that. =]



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